
Echoes from the Periphery: Modelling Media Networks of the 1969 Apollo Landing in Authoritarian Portugal

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Abstract

The 1969 Moon landing represented not only a technological milestone but also a moment of intense media circulation with wide-reaching cultural and ideological impact (Dick and Launius, 2007). In Portugal, under the Estado Novo regime, national newspapers revealed a layered mix of enthusiasm, skepticism, and regime-aligned identity narratives. This paper examines how seven Portuguese newspapers, *O Século*, *Diário de Lisboa*, *Diário Popular*, *A Capital*, *Flama*, *Diário do Sul*, and *Avante!*, structured and mediated the Apollo 11 event between 16 and 25 July 1969, addressing the research question: how did ideological positioning shape press mediation of a global scientific event in an authoritarian peripheral context? The corpus comprises over 530 references to the Apollo 11 mission, extracted via PaddleOCR and manually verified for quality control. Textual data were divided into two repositories: one tracking publication metadata and thematic frequencies, the other encoding semantic relationships and narrative frames. These data points were semantically modelled using Protégé, based on the CIDOC CRM (Doerr, 2003), and queried via Apache Jena Fuseki. The ontology structured entities including articles, actors, locations, and visual elements, caricatures, photographs, infographics, emphasising relationships such as publication context, ideological tone, and co-occurring themes. Additional strategies were drawn from recent applications of the model in multimodal artefact analysis (Liang et al., 2025).

The resulting network reveals three findings. First, the Portuguese press consistently framed Apollo 11 as a triumph of Western science, amplifying NASA's narrative while systematically silencing Soviet actors. Second, ideological differentiation between outlets was marked: *Avante!*, the clandestine Communist party newspaper, offered a counter-narrative structurally absent from regime-aligned press. Third, the network identified previously overlooked agents whose participation in the Space Age has not been documented in existing historiography.

These findings show that Portugal was not a passive receiver of Space Age knowledge. Press mediation of Apollo 11 reveals an active negotiation between regime ideology, scientific enthusiasm, and transnational knowledge circulation, a dynamic that ontological modelling makes visible and queryable in ways traditional close reading cannot.

This contribution demonstrates how fragmented historical sources can be coherently modelled through network thinking, aligning with the HNR 2026 theme "Sources" and offering transferable ontological tools for studying media, science, and identity in peripheral modern

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contexts.

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